

SONIA WILL BE HARD-PRESSED TO CHOOSE BETWEEN THE ADVICE OF HER PARTY LEADERS AND THAT OF THE CHURCH



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meddling in our affairs. We will not tolerate big brothers." The mutual war of words between the UDF constituents was so shrill that a Nandigram-like police repression near Kozhikode, where locals resisting land acquisition for a highway were brutally beaten up by the police, has been lost in the political din.

Despite the stiff opposition, Mani and Joseph appear confident that they will be in the UDF. The reason is the backing of the powerful Catholic Church's support to the merger move. Both leaders know that the Congress cannot ignore the Church, which has immense clout with the state's Christian community that constitutes 19 per cent of Kerala's population. They are confident that the Church can convince All India Congress Committee (AICC) President Sonia Gandhi to accept their move. For long, a large section of the Syro-Malabar Church, the largest Catholic church in the country, has been urging the KC to join the community in its fight against the communist-led LDF. The community's main grouse is the LDF Government's attempts to regulate the private education sector dominated by the Church. "We don't meddle in

religious affairs. Likewise the Church too should restrain its activities to the religious realm and not meddle in politics," sniped Pinarayi Vijayan, CPI(M) state secretary. The church has rubbished this charge as a CPI(M) ploy to win Hindu votes. "They are trying to whip up anti-Christian sentiments. It's reminiscent of Hitler's tactics in Germany to incite anti-Jewish passions," said a statement issued by a church organisation.

It is no secret that with Christian and Muslim groups deserting it in droves, the LDF has begun to eye Hindu votes. Just after the KC left, the LDF decided to shelve its proposed bill—opposed by Hindu groups—to control the Travancore Devaswom Board which administers the state's temples. Hindu groups have welcomed the decision. The lame duck LDF is now pinning hopes on a consolidation of all secular votes in its favour once all the communal organisations find place in the UDF. The Left is encouraged by its own past when in the 1987 Assembly elections, it notched up an impressive win after it formed an all-secular front driving out all communally-inclined minority parties like the many Kerala Congress factions and the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) to the UDF. The UDF's present opposition to KC's entry too is fuelled by its fear of a Hindu backlash against the Front becoming a bandwagon of all minority community groups.

But the fingerpointing in the UDF does not mitigate the LDF's mounting troubles with the minorities. Despite its loud claim of being a champion of secularism, most minority organisations in Kerala today see the Left as their sworn enemy. The campaign against the Left is led by the Church, especially after the Government's attempts to regulate the private education sector. Before the KC deserted it, several prominent leaders of the CPI(M), both Muslims and Christians, had left the LDF, terming it anti-minority. The Muslim-dominated Indian National League (INL), a long-term electoral ally of the LDF too is planning to sever its links with the Left and merge with the IUML. With minor-



MANI

JOSEPH

SPLITSVILLE

The birth and the growth pangs of the Kerala Congress

1964: Fifteen MLAs of the Congress split to form the Kerala Congress (KC).

1965: KC contests Assembly polls alone and wins 25 out of 140 seats.

1969: Tastes power for the first time as it joins CPI-Congress ministry.

1972: Distances itself from the Congress and aligns with the CPI(M).

1975: Back again with the Congress; joins the UDF cabinet.

1979: KC splits and dominant faction KC-Mani joins the LDF.

1982: KC-Mani returns to the UDF.

1989: KC moves to the LDF.

2010: Both merge to join the UDF.